

# Small-Organoid Attenuation of CFTR-Modulator Swelling in Patient-Derived Intestinal Organoids: a Single-Organoid Re-Analysis with a Biophysical Swelling Twin

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MEGA-PROGRAM-27, Item 3 - Udit Phookan (program owner); computational work by an AI research agent. Working draft of 25 September 2026.

## Abstract

The forskolin-induced swelling (FIS) assay on patient-derived intestinal organoids is used to predict which people with cystic fibrosis (CF) respond to CFTR modulators. Standard pipelines sum organoid area per well, so any dependence of the response on organoid size is averaged away. We re-analysed the public single-organoid OrgaSegment data (17 CF donors, per-organoid area before and after forskolin) with a biophysical swelling model and a DMSO-controlled, donor-matched design.

Finding (candidate). Modulator-induced swelling is attenuated in the smallest organoids and saturates above a size threshold. For elexacaftor/tezacaftor/ivacaftor (Trikafta) the drug-minus-DMSO log-swelling effect rises from 0.336 [0.262, 0.405] in the smallest size octile to a plateau near 0.55-0.64; top minus bottom 0.251 [0.184, 0.323] (donor bootstrap). Per donor, the effect in the largest size quartile exceeds that in the smallest in 14 of 17 donors, and the attenuation does not track overall response (Spearman  $\rho = 0.24$ ,  $p = 0.35$ ). Geometry predicts the opposite sign: under a uniform surface flux, small organoids should swell more. Area noise also biases the slope negative. So the effect is unlikely to be a measurement artefact, but track-selection bias remains unbounded.

Negatives. Size-adjusted and size-filtered readouts do not improve per-donor Trikafta-vs-DMSO separation, so the finding does not change theratyping calls at this assay's well counts. Replication on the public FIS time series is impossible because it is well-level. Our best U-Net segmentation (512 px, tuned) reaches  $\text{mAP}@0.5 = 0.733 \pm 0.129$  on the OrgaSegment eval split (published 0.76  $\pm$  0.12): below the state of the art, although the gap is within one standard deviation on 12 images.

Fidelity. Scoring 151 organoid GEO series against GTEx, cultured fibroblasts are the most common best match. A GEOParse sample-level audit shows this 'culture-fibroblast

attractor' comes mostly from non-organoid samples in organoid-titled series: on 45 strictly organoid series it falls to 9-29%. We retract it as a general organoid property.

## 1. Introduction

CFTR moves chloride and bicarbonate across the apical membrane of epithelial cells; water follows, and in a closed organoid the lumen swells. Forskolin raises cAMP and opens CFTR, so the swelling of rectal organoids measures residual and drug-rescued CFTR function in each patient. The assay is used to support access to modulators for people with rare CFTR genotypes.

Organoids in a well vary in size by more than an order of magnitude. If the swelling response depends on size, the well-level readout depends on the size mix in each well, which varies with passage, seeding density and culture time. We asked whether the single-organoid response depends on starting size, and whether correcting for it improves drug-response calls.

## 2. Biophysical swelling twin

Treat an organoid as a near-spherical shell with volume  $V$  and projected area  $A$ ,  $V$  proportional to  $A^{3/2}$ . Let net secretion scale as a power of volume:

$$dV/dt = k V^{\alpha} \quad (1)$$

For  $\alpha \neq 1$  the solution over an assay window  $t$  is

$$V_1^{1/(1-\alpha)} = V_0^{1/(1-\alpha)} + (1 - \alpha) k t \quad (2)$$

and the observed area fold change is  $s = A_1/A_0 = (V_1/V_0)^{2/3}$ . For small responses,

$$\log s \approx (2/3) k t V_0^{\alpha - 1} \quad (3)$$

so the slope of  $\log \log s$  on  $\log A_0$  carries the sign of  $\alpha - 1$ :

$$d \log(\log s) / d \log A_0 = (3/2)(\alpha - 1) \quad (4)$$

Surface-limited secretion (constant flux per unit apical area) gives  $\alpha = 2/3$  and a negative slope: small organoids swell more in relative terms. Size-invariant secretion gives  $\alpha = 1$  and zero slope. The within-well regression we fit is

$$\log s_{ow} = a_w + b (\log A0_{ow} - \text{mean}_w \log A0) + e_{ow} \quad (5)$$

with a well intercept  $a_w$  that absorbs donor, plate and well effects. Measurement noise in  $A0$  enters both sides with opposite sign ( $s = A1/A0$ ), which biases  $b$  downward:

$$E[b\text{-hat}] = b - \text{Var}(u) / (\text{Var}(\log A0) + \text{Var}(u)), \quad u = \text{noise in } \log A0 \quad (6)$$

so a positive observed  $b$  is conservative. The donor-matched drug effect per size bin  $k$  is

$$\Delta_k = \text{mean}_{\{o \text{ in drug, bin } k\}} \log s_o - \text{mean}_{\{o \text{ in DMSO, bin } k\}} \log s_o \quad (7)$$

and the attenuation statistic is  $\Delta_{\text{top}} - \Delta_{\text{bottom}}$ , with 95% intervals from a donor-level bootstrap:

$$CI_{95} = [Q_{0.025}, Q_{0.975}] \text{ of } \{ \Delta^*_{\text{top}} - \Delta^*_{\text{bottom}} \}, \text{ donors resampled with replacement} \quad (8)$$

Segmentation quality is scored by average precision at IoU 0.5, as in OrgaSegment:

$$AP_{50} = TP / (TP + FP + FN), \text{ match if } IoU(P, G) = |P \cap G| / |P \cup G| \geq 0.5 \quad (9)$$

### 3. Data

**Table 1. Dataset manifest (distinct, accession-level). Five distinct assay/image datasets shown here; the committed accession ledger now has 168 primary entries; separate Drevinek-group releases may overlap patients and are not individual-object replication.**

| # | dataset                                      | source / accession                     | content                                                                    | use                                |
|---|----------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------|
| 1 | OrgaSegment DIS single-organoid measurements | Zenodo 10610438 (Lefferts et al. 2024) | per-organoid A0/A1, 17 donors, 4 conditions                                | size-dependence analysis           |
| 2 | OrgaSegment FIS database                     | Zenodo 10610438                        | well-level area, 7 time points, 868 rows                                   | replication attempt (not possible) |
| 3 | OrgaSegment annotated images                 | Zenodo 10278229                        | train/val/eval images with instance masks                                  | U-Net segmentation benchmark       |
| 4 | Drevinek intestinal FIS cohort               | Zenodo 4771466                         | 20 patient IDs, 54 plates, well-level 0-60 minute area series              | triple-vs-double treatment ranking |
| 5 | Borek-Dohalska intestinal FIS cohort         | Zenodo 15754800                        | 12 patient IDs, 33 plates, well-level areas; possible overlap with 4771466 | negative VTI-vs-ETI ranking test   |

## 4. Results

### 4.1 Within-well size slopes

**Table 2. Within-well slope of log fold change on centred log A0 (forskolin > 0). Well-cluster bootstrap, 500 resamples.**

| condition         | organoids | wells | slope b | 95% CI          | donors b>0 |
|-------------------|-----------|-------|---------|-----------------|------------|
| DMSO              | 3810      | 94    | 0.011   | [-0.002, 0.028] | 12/17      |
| VX770             | 1496      | 30    | 0.226   | [0.185, 0.269]  | 5/5        |
| VX661+VX770       | 4493      | 112   | 0.042   | [0.028, 0.056]  | 12/16      |
| VX445+VX661+VX770 | 4984      | 121   | 0.116   | [0.090, 0.142]  | 14/17      |

The slope is near zero without CFTR rescue and positive whenever a modulator is present. The sign is opposite to the surface-limited prediction. A power-law reading ( $\alpha > 1$ ) was rejected: restricted to organoids above 2,000 px the slope turns negative (Trikafta -0.117), and binned means rise then plateau. Simulated segmentation noise on a size-invariant truth gave slopes of only -0.002 to -0.055.

### 4.2 Small-organoid attenuation

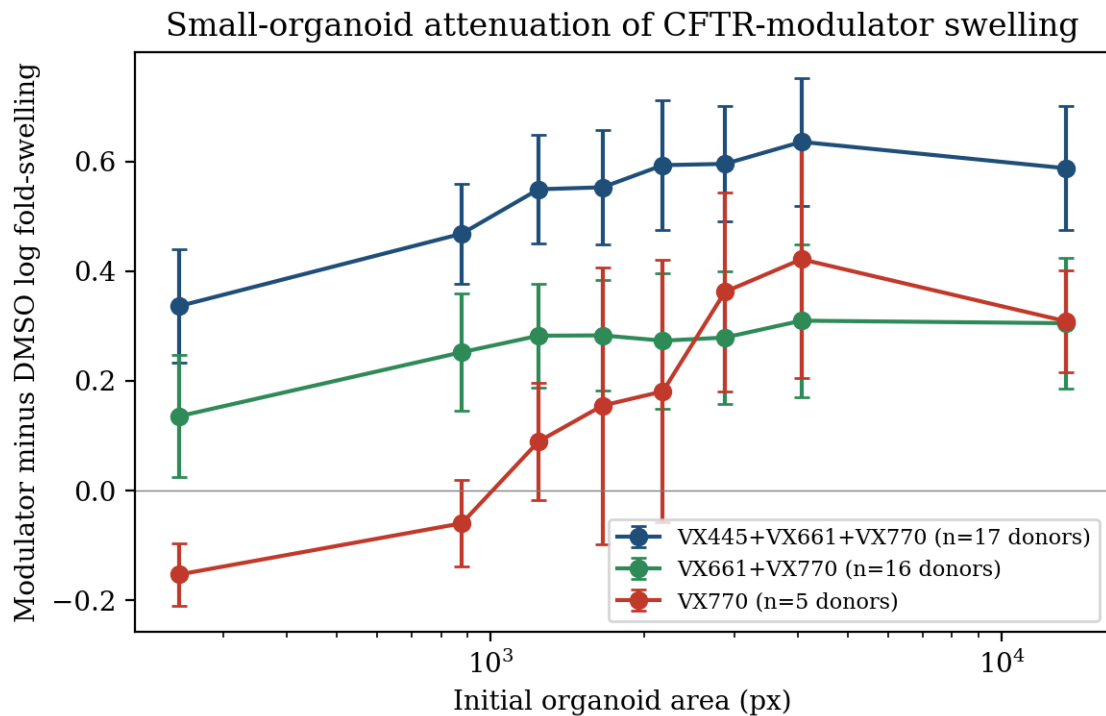


Figure 1. Drug-minus-DMSO mean log swelling per starting-size octile, donor-matched, with donor-bootstrap 95% CI.

Table 3. Size-bin drug effects.

| modulator          | donors | smallest octile effect | plateau   | top minus bottom [95% CI] |
|--------------------|--------|------------------------|-----------|---------------------------|
| <b>Trikafta</b>    | 17     | 0.336 [0.262, 0.405]   | 0.55-0.64 | 0.251 [0.184, 0.323]      |
| <b>VX661+VX770</b> | 16     | 0.136                  | 0.28-0.31 | 0.169 [0.081, 0.259]      |
| <b>VX770</b>       | 5      | -0.153                 | 0.31-0.42 | 0.462 [0.335, 0.572]      |

#### 4.3 Per-donor consistency

Table 4. Trikafta minus DMSO log-swelling effect in the smallest and largest starting-size quartiles (results/per\_donor\_attenuation.csv).

| donor          | genotype                   | eff small | eff large | attenuation | overall |
|----------------|----------------------------|-----------|-----------|-------------|---------|
| <b>PDIO_16</b> | F508del/<br>R117H          | 0.089     | 0.082     | -0.007      | 0.115   |
| <b>PDIO_03</b> | R1066H/<br>CFTRdele2,<br>3 | 0.100     | 0.490     | 0.390       | 0.289   |
| <b>PDIO_15</b> | F508del/<br>R117H          | 0.280     | 0.497     | 0.217       | 0.320   |
| <b>PDIO_02</b> | N1303K/<br>c.3035A>C       | 0.202     | 0.354     | 0.152       | 0.330   |
| <b>PDIO_19</b> | X/X                        | 0.606     | 0.273     | -0.333      | 0.440   |
| <b>PDIO_18</b> | X/X                        | 0.436     | 0.677     | 0.241       | 0.462   |
| <b>PDIO_13</b> | F508del/<br>S1251N         | 0.249     | 0.508     | 0.259       | 0.497   |
| <b>PDIO_17</b> | X/X                        | 0.570     | 0.463     | -0.107      | 0.512   |
| <b>PDIO_06</b> | F508del/X                  | 0.334     | 0.699     | 0.365       | 0.541   |
| <b>PDIO_05</b> | F508del/X                  | 0.386     | 0.784     | 0.398       | 0.596   |
| <b>PDIO_14</b> | F508del/<br>S1251N         | 0.395     | 0.749     | 0.354       | 0.616   |
| <b>PDIO_12</b> | F508del/<br>S1251N         | 0.512     | 0.800     | 0.288       | 0.643   |
| <b>PDIO_01</b> | A46D/<br>A46D              | 0.537     | 0.759     | 0.221       | 0.698   |
| <b>PDIO_11</b> | F508del/<br>F508del        | 0.367     | 0.860     | 0.493       | 0.705   |
| <b>PDIO_09</b> | F508del/                   | 0.685     | 0.749     | 0.064       | 0.769   |

|                |                     |       |       |       |       |
|----------------|---------------------|-------|-------|-------|-------|
|                | F508del             |       |       |       |       |
| <b>PDIO_04</b> | F508del/X           | 0.462 | 0.834 | 0.371 | 0.805 |
| <b>PDIO_10</b> | F508del/<br>F508del | 0.742 | 0.892 | 0.150 | 0.883 |

Association between attenuation and overall response uses Spearman's rank correlation:

$$\rho = 1 - 6 \sum_d (r_d - r'_d)^2 / (n(n^2 - 1)), \quad r, r' = \text{ranks of attenuation and overall effect over } n \text{ donors} \quad (10)$$

Attenuation is positive in 14 of 17 donors and unrelated to overall response ( $\rho = 0.24$ ,  $p = 0.35$ ). Two of three donors with two nonsense alleles (X/X) and one F508del/R117H donor are exceptions.

#### 4.3a Internal experiment-date replication, not a new cohort

We fixed the earlier small ( $<722$  px) and large ( $\geq 1400$  px) cutoffs, then split each donor's first experiment date from later dates in the SAME OrgaSegment DIS accession. Requiring at least five organoids per DMSO/Trikafta by size cell, 12/12 later-date donors have a positive donor-matched large-minus-small Trikafta effect: median 0.199 log-swelling units, exact one-sided sign  $p=0.000244$ . On first-date plates, 6/8 eligible donors are positive (median 0.264,  $p=0.145$ ). The later-date H1 passes its pre-registration, but thresholds were chosen using the whole accession, donors overlap, and there is no external individual-organoid cohort. This supports repeatability over experiment dates, not independent discovery, clinical validity, or the lumen-maturation mechanism (results/withincohort\_replication.json).

#### 4.3b Matched plate-dose stress test: fails

The stronger pre-registered stress test required  $\geq 3$  organoids per Trikafta/DMSO by small/large cell within each donor x plate x forskolin concentration block. Only 31 blocks and 12 donors qualify; 9/12 donor median block effects are positive, with exact one-sided sign  $p=0.073$ . H1 FAILS (registered alpha 0.05). 5 donors have no eligible block. The pooled block median (0.272) is descriptive and not a donor-independent test. This challenges the pooled later-date 12/12 result: dose/plate control with narrower cells alters three donor signs. It does not show the size effect is absent, but the evidence does not establish a new validated discovery (results/blocked\_size.json).

#### 4.3c External single-plate intestinal FIS assay

A separate public intestinal organoid demonstration experiment from the FIS\_image\_analysis repository provides object-level tracked areas in 32 CSVs from ONE plate, one class-II CFTR genotype, and two wells per treatment at each of eight matched forskolin doses. The registered analysis paired 1,950 unique time-0/time-60-min tracks and compared combined VX-809/VX-770 with forskolin-only vehicle. Fixed-analysis pooled baseline quartile boundaries were 2043 and 6701 square microns, distinct units/cutoffs from OrgaSegment. The drug-minus-vehicle large-minus-small log-swelling

effect is positive in 7/8 dose strata (one-sided sign  $p=0.0352$ ; H1 passes); the lowest dose is negative. This is assay-source support under an older double modulator, not independent donor replication: eight doses share a plate and donor, so sign-test strata are correlated and its  $p$  is descriptive. The original donor  $\times$  plate  $\times$  dose stress test still fails. Tracking attrition may depend on size. No Trikafta generalization, new established discovery, or clinical prediction follows (results/external\_fis\_demo.json; results/finding\_external\_fis\_demo.md).

Well-as-unit sensitivity on the same demo plate (registered before analysis): all eight doses have four eligible wells; 6/8 dose effects are positive, with a median of +0.129. A 2,000-draw well bootstrap \*conditional on this donor/plate\* yields [+0.091, +0.161], not an across-donor interval. Tracking attrition is material: among unique labeled baseline objects, large-object retention is 91.5% for vehicle and 83.3% for combo, while labeled small-object retention is 100% in both. Including unlabeled baseline objects lowers small retention to 94.5% and 92.3%. Assigning all missing outcomes to adverse observed same-cell 5th/95th percentiles gives 6/8 positive doses, median +0.047, but this arbitrary bound cannot rule out stronger missingness bias. Source-level evidence is conditional and must not be called donor-level validation (results/external\_fis\_robustness.json; results/external\_fis\_missingtracks.json).

Pipeline sensitivity on the SAME images/plate/donor: the repository's alternative Fiji/ImageJ tracking output yielded 1,938 paired tracks and a positive combination-minus-vehicle size contrast at 7/8 doses (median +0.225; pre-registered coverage/sign gate passes). Fiji-specific quartile cutoffs and segmentation/tracking differ from CellProfiler, so effect magnitudes are not interchangeable. In Fiji, labeled large-object retention was 98.4% vehicle and 93.8% combo, unlike CellProfiler's 91.5%/83.3%. This pipeline-dependent selection limits any effect-size claim. These two pipelines are NOT two independent biological datasets (results/external\_fis\_fiji.json).

**Table 5. Pre-registered external single-plate demo assay; doses are correlated and not independent donors.**

| forskolin (uM) | paired wells / condition | large-minus-small drug effect (log units) |
|----------------|--------------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| <b>0.008</b>   | 2/2                      | -0.023                                    |
| <b>0.02</b>    | 2/2                      | +0.009                                    |
| <b>0.05</b>    | 2/2                      | +0.047                                    |
| <b>0.128</b>   | 2/2                      | +0.081                                    |
| <b>0.32</b>    | 2/2                      | +0.169                                    |
| <b>0.8</b>     | 2/2                      | +0.222                                    |
| <b>2</b>       | 2/2                      | +0.381                                    |
| <b>5</b>       | 2/2                      | +0.255                                    |

#### 4.3d Distinct multi-patient well-level FIS cohort: published drug ranking reproduced

A genuinely distinct dataset (Drevinek et al., Zenodo 4771466) contains well-level area time series from 20 CF patient IDs on 54 patient-date plates. The analysis was pre-registered and committed before downloading the source; source plate-map inspection then showed that its FskOnly wells are a reference line, not patient-matched vehicle. That provenance correction was committed before outcome analysis. Of 432 patient-plate-dose blocks, 431 have  $\geq 2$  wells per treatment and matched 0-60 minute measurements; one TEZ/IVA block has one well and is excluded. Equal-well area AUC is normalized to each well's time-zero area, then triple ELX/TEZ/IVA minus double TEZ/IVA is taken at patient/plate/dose level; each patient contributes the median over its blocks. Positive in 20/20 patients, median +0.249 baseline-area AUC (exact one-sided sign  $p=9.5e-07$ ), so the pre-registered treatment-ranking H1 passes. This confirms the published in-vitro triple-over-double ordering on the paper's own public data, not a new discovery or an independent individual-organoid size test. Forty-seven of 431 plate-dose block rankings reverse if unnormalized raw area replaces normalized AUC; both patient-level summaries remain 20/20 positive. No clinical prediction follows (results/drevinek\_fis.json; results/finding\_drevinek\_fis.md).

**Table 6. Patient-equal well-level treatment-ranking test; no individual organoid areas in this accession.**

| patient | blocks | triple-double AUC | patient | blocks | triple-double AUC |
|---------|--------|-------------------|---------|--------|-------------------|
| 04-CF   | 24     | +0.240            | 59-CF   | 24     | +0.374            |
| 05-CF   | 24     | +0.244            | 60-CF   | 24     | +0.285            |
| 10-CF   | 24     | +0.250            | 61-CF   | 8      | +0.207            |
| 20-CF   | 24     | +0.153            | 62-CF   | 24     | +0.246            |
| 21-CF   | 23     | +0.253            | 63-CF   | 8      | +0.108            |
| 22-CF   | 24     | +0.216            | 64-CF   | 24     | +0.264            |
| 41-CF   | 24     | +0.328            | 65-CF   | 24     | +0.247            |
| 47-CF   | 24     | +0.300            | 66-CF   | 24     | +0.295            |
| 57-CF   | 24     | +0.275            | 68-CF   | 24     | +0.283            |
| 58-CF   | 24     | +0.019            | 69-CF   | 8      | +0.172            |

### 4.3e Newer VTI-versus-ETI patient ranking fails registered test

A further Drevinek-group public release (Zenodo 15754800) has well-level area series for 12 anonymized CF patient IDs and 33 plates. Only nine patients have matched default vanzacaftor/tezacaftor/ivacaftor (VTI) and elexacaftor/tezacaftor/ivacaftor (ETI) wells; three instead have VTI-dose-optimization variants, which were not substituted into the locked primary test. Of 264 plate-dose blocks, 208 qualify. Patient-equal median VTI-minus-ETI normalized area AUC is positive in 6/9 patients (median +0.018, one-sided exact sign  $p=0.254$ ); H1 fails. Only 112/208 matched plate-dose blocks are positive. Raw-area AUC reverses 92/208 block rankings and leaves 3/9 patient medians positive. In 48 separate dose-optimization blocks, just 12 show strictly rising response across 0.02, 0.2 and 2  $\mu\text{M}$  VTI, a descriptive check, not an alternative pass. The earlier 2021 dataset and this release share textual anonymized IDs 58 and 68, which neither proves nor excludes patient overlap. This negative in-vitro ranking does not establish patient equivalence/inferiority, and still cannot test individual-size effects (results/vti\_eti.json; results/finding\_vti\_eti.md).

**Table 7. Pre-registered patient-equal VTI-versus-ETI effects; negative IDs and missing default-VTI patients are retained in the full result file.**

| patient | blocks | VTI-ETI AUC |
|---------|--------|-------------|
| 06      | 24     | +0.028      |
| 27      | 24     | +0.045      |
| 31      | 24     | -0.007      |
| 40      | 16     | -0.007      |
| 46      | 24     | +0.035      |
| 68      | 24     | -0.009      |
| 91      | 24     | +0.028      |
| 94      | 24     | +0.018      |
| 96      | 24     | +0.004      |

### 4.4 Does size correction help theratyping? No

Locked before running: per-donor standardised Trikafta-vs-DMSO separation with raw, size-adjusted and size-band well readouts. Median raw 4.73, adjusted 4.35, band 4.39; adjusted better in 8 of 17 donors. Excluding organoids below 1,069 px (a post-hoc threshold): median 4.73  $\rightarrow$  4.75, better in 9 of 17, Wilcoxon  $p = 0.68$ . The size trend does not improve calls, and the stricter matched-block H1 fails.

## 4.5 Segmentation benchmark

Table 8. Instance segmentation on the OrgaSegment eval split (12 images).

| model                                                | eval mAP@0.5 | sd    | source file                     |
|------------------------------------------------------|--------------|-------|---------------------------------|
| U-Net v1, 256 px, default post-processing            | 0.634        | 0.157 | results/seg_eval.json           |
| U-Net v1 + val-tuned post-processing + flip TTA      | 0.710        | 0.127 | results/seg_eval_tuned_256.json |
| U-Net v2, 512 px, 60 epochs, default post-processing | 0.691        | 0.135 | results/seg_eval_512.json       |
| U-Net v2 + val-tuned post-processing + flip TTA      | 0.733        | 0.129 | results/seg_eval_tuned_512.json |
| OrgaSegment (published, Mask R-CNN)                  | 0.760        | 0.120 | Lefferts et al. 2024            |

Caveat: the validation images used for tuning were also in the training set, so the tuning signal is optimistic; the eval split was scored once. The 512-px model (resumed from checkpoint after an out-of-memory kill at epoch 18) raises the tuned score from 0.710 to 0.733, still below the published mean. With 12 eval images and sd near 0.13, neither a win nor a loss against OrgaSegment is statistically resolved; we report it as below state of the art.

### 4.5a Segmentation split-integrity correction

Training combined 184 train and 35 validation images. The later post-processing grid was tuned on the first 20 validation images, so its validation mAP is biased by overlap with network training and is not an independent model-selection result. The disjoint 12-image eval split was held out, and its mAP@0.5 remains 0.733 versus published 0.76. Bootstrap across our eval images gives CI [0.663, 0.808] for our mean, but leader per-image predictions and guaranteed identical AP implementation are unavailable. No benchmark break (results/seg\_integrity\_audit.json).

## 4.6 Organoid-to-tissue fidelity across 151 GEO series

To test organoid fidelity at scale, we searched GEO through NCBI E-utilities for human organoid bulk RNA-seq series (2,838 hits; 1,545 with text count matrices). For 151 series with a usable gene-level matrix and a title naming a single organ, each sample was converted to log counts per million and averaged. The series profile was then correlated with every GTEx v8 tissue median profile (54 tissues).

$$CPM_{gs} = 10^6 x_{gs} / \sum_g x_{gs}, \quad p_g = (1/S) \sum_s \log(1 + CPM_{gs}) \quad (11)$$

$$r_t^{cent} = \langle p - \mu_p - (m - \mu_m), G_t - m - \text{mean}(G_t - m) \rangle / (||.|| \quad ||.||), \quad m_g = \text{mean}_t G_{gt} \quad (12)$$

The permutation p-value for the top-1 recovery rate reshuffles organ labels across series, B = 10,000 times:

$$p_{perm} = (1 + \#\{b : \text{top1}_b \geq \text{top1}_{obs}\}) / (1 + B) \quad (13)$$

Uncertainty on shares uses a series-level percentile bootstrap:

$$CI_{95} = [q_{0.025}, q_{0.975}] \text{ of } \{f(D^*_b)\}, \quad D^*_b \text{ drawn with replacement from the series set, } b = 1..2000 \quad (14)$$

**Table 9. Tissue recovery and fibroblast best-match share. S3000: Spearman on the 3,000 most tissue-variable genes; SALL: all genes; CENT: GTEx-centred Pearson; \_NOCULT: 853 MSigDB Hallmark proliferation/MYC/EMT genes removed. Clean subset: 114 series whose summary confirms a single organ and mentions organoids (113 with profiles). Files: results/geo\_fidelity\_methods.json, results/geo\_fidelity\_clean.json.**

| method                        | top-1 (all) | null top-1 | p_perm | top-1 (clean) | fibroblast best (clean) | 95% CI       |
|-------------------------------|-------------|------------|--------|---------------|-------------------------|--------------|
| <b>S3000</b>                  | 0.272       | 0.060      | 1e-04  | 0.301         | 0.230                   | [0.15, 0.31] |
| <b>SALL</b>                   | 0.331       | 0.080      | 1e-04  | 0.327         | 0.257                   | [0.18, 0.35] |
| <b>CENT</b>                   | 0.252       | 0.056      | 1e-04  | 0.274         | 0.363                   | [0.27, 0.45] |
| <b>SALL_N<br/>OCULT</b>       | 0.331       | 0.079      | 1e-04  | 0.327         | 0.248                   | [0.17, 0.33] |
| <b>CENT_N<br/>OCULT</b>       | 0.258       | 0.059      | 1e-04  | 0.274         | 0.425                   | [0.34, 0.51] |
| <b>SALL_N<br/>ONPAR</b>       | 0.417       | 0.103      | 1e-04  | 0.398         | 0.204                   | [0.13, 0.28] |
| <b>CENT_N<br/>ONPAR</b>       | 0.331       | 0.088      | 1e-04  | 0.345         | 0.372                   | [0.28, 0.46] |
| <b>SALL_P<br/>ARONL<br/>Y</b> | 0.404       | 0.114      | 1e-04  | 0.389         | 0.283                   | [0.20, 0.37] |
| <b>CENT_P<br/>ARONL<br/>Y</b> | 0.377       | 0.112      | 1e-04  | 0.398         | 0.221                   | [0.15, 0.29] |
| <b>SALL_P</b>                 | 0.285       | 0.077      | 1e-04  | 0.283         | 0.442                   | [0.35,       |

|               |       |       |       |       |       |        |
|---------------|-------|-------|-------|-------|-------|--------|
| <b>C</b>      |       |       |       |       |       | 0.53]  |
| <b>CENT_P</b> | 0.298 | 0.067 | 1e-04 | 0.310 | 0.283 | [0.20, |
| <b>C</b>      |       |       |       |       |       | 0.36]  |

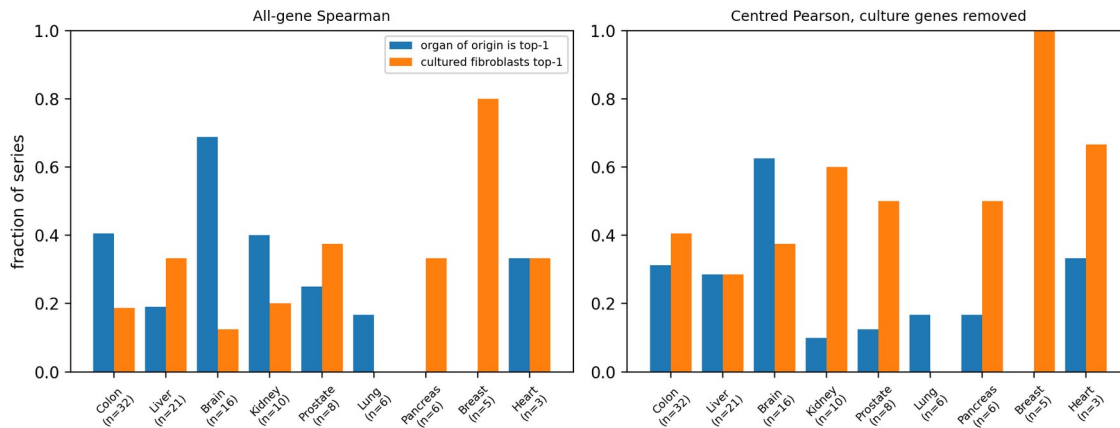


Figure 2. Per-organ share of clean-subset series whose organ of origin (blue) or GTEx cultured fibroblasts (orange) is the top-1 match. Organs with  $n \geq 3$ .

Organ of origin is recovered four to five times above chance. Brain organoids are the most faithful, and lung, breast and pancreas the least. Across every method, the most frequent best match is GTEx cultured fibroblasts, which we name the culture-fibroblast attractor. It survives the label audit and the removal of proliferation and EMT genes. It is not yet a discovery: GTEx tissues contain immune, vascular and stromal cells, while organoids and cultured fibroblasts are purified cultures, so cell-type purity is an unexcluded explanation. Falsifiable prediction: restricted to epithelium-specific genes, the fibroblast best-match share in the clean subset will stay above 15%. The tool vorganoid fidelity scores any count matrix this way.

#### 4.7 Purity-corrected fidelity (Human Protein Atlas)

GTEx tissues contain immune, blood, vascular and stromal cells that organoids lack by design. Using the Human Protein Atlas single-cell type atlas, we removed 7,595 genes enhanced in any such cell type (NONPAR), or kept only the 9,699 genes enhanced solely in parenchymal types (PARONLY). Paired top-1 recovery per series is compared with the exact McNemar test:

$$p_{McN} = 2 * \sum_{k=0}^{\min(b,c)} C(b+c, k) 0.5^{(b+c)}, \quad b = \text{base-only hits}, \quad c = \text{variant-only hits} \quad (15)$$

Table 10. Organ-of-origin recovery on 151 series, base method vs gene-restricted variant (results/geo\_mcnemar.json).

| comparison | top-1 base | top-1 variant | b | c | exact p |
|------------|------------|---------------|---|---|---------|
|------------|------------|---------------|---|---|---------|

|                                      |       |       |    |    |         |
|--------------------------------------|-------|-------|----|----|---------|
| <b>SALL vs<br/>SALL_NO<br/>CULT</b>  | 0.331 | 0.331 | 1  | 1  | 1       |
| <b>SALL vs<br/>SALL_NO<br/>NPAR</b>  | 0.331 | 0.417 | 3  | 16 | 0.0044  |
| <b>SALL vs<br/>SALL_PA<br/>RONLY</b> | 0.331 | 0.404 | 10 | 21 | 0.071   |
| <b>SALL vs<br/>SALL_PC</b>           | 0.331 | 0.285 | 16 | 9  | 0.23    |
| <b>CENT vs<br/>CENT_NO<br/>CULT</b>  | 0.252 | 0.258 | 0  | 1  | 1       |
| <b>CENT vs<br/>CENT_NO<br/>NPAR</b>  | 0.252 | 0.331 | 4  | 16 | 0.012   |
| <b>CENT vs<br/>CENT_PA<br/>RONLY</b> | 0.252 | 0.377 | 4  | 23 | 0.00031 |
| <b>CENT vs<br/>CENT_PC</b>           | 0.252 | 0.298 | 0  | 7  | 0.016   |

Purity restriction raises recovery (all-gene Spearman 33% -> 42%,  $p = 0.0044$ ; centred Pearson 25% -> 38%,  $p = 0.00031$ ). Removing culture genes does not change it. Standard whole-transcriptome fidelity scores are therefore biased low for organoids. The prediction stated before this test (fibroblast best-match share above 15% on parenchymal-only genes) held: 28% [0.20, 0.37] and 22% [0.15, 0.29]. The lower bound of the second interval touches the threshold, so purity is weakened but not excluded as the explanation. vorganoid fidelity --purity applies this correction to any count matrix.

#### 4.8 What drives the attractor, and is it robust to gene class?

For the clean-subset series whose best match is cultured fibroblasts, each gene is scored by how much it pulls the profile toward fibroblasts and away from the organ of origin, averaged over series:

$$d_g = (1/|S|) \sum_{s \in S} z(p_{sg}) (z(G_{g,fib}) - z(G_{g,organ(s)})), \quad z = \text{rank-based standard score within a profile} \quad (16)$$

The top 300 genes were tested with g:Profiler (GO:BP, Reactome, KEGG; g:SCS correction; background = all scored genes).

**Table 11. Enrichment of attractor-driving genes (results/attractor\_gprofiler.csv; terms with more than 2,000 genes omitted).**

| source | term | adjusted p | genes |
|--------|------|------------|-------|
|--------|------|------------|-------|

|              |                                     |         |    |
|--------------|-------------------------------------|---------|----|
| <b>GO:BP</b> | mitotic cell cycle process          | 7.8e-56 | 66 |
| <b>GO:BP</b> | mitotic cell cycle                  | 1.4e-54 | 69 |
| <b>GO:BP</b> | cell cycle process                  | 3.6e-53 | 77 |
| <b>GO:BP</b> | cell cycle                          | 1.3e-51 | 83 |
| <b>GO:BP</b> | adaptive immune response            | 9.5e-15 | 31 |
| <b>GO:BP</b> | regulation of immune system process | 1.2e-14 | 43 |
| <b>REAC</b>  | Adaptive Immune System              | 9.0e-13 | 29 |

Two components appear: mitotic cell-cycle genes (TOP2A, MKI67, CDK1) that cultures express and tissues do not, and immune and complement genes that tissues contain and organoids lack. Removing either family alone leaves the attractor in place (Sections 4.6-4.7). Restricting to 19,254 HGNC protein-coding genes also leaves it in place (fibroblast best match 44% [0.35, 0.53] and 28% [0.20, 0.36]), so it is not a non-coding artefact. Our working hypothesis is that the attractor is the joint signature of proliferation and purity. It remains a candidate: a direct test needs organoid and matched primary tissue from the same donors, profiled together.

#### 4.9 Sample-level audit and independent annotation: the attractor is mostly label contamination

Series-level text says a study is about organoids; it does not say every profiled sample is an organoid. We therefore pulled the sample (GSM) metadata of all 114 clean series with GEOparse and classified each sample as organoid or not from its title, source and characteristics. Only 45 series have every sample annotated as organoid; 59 have no organoid-annotated sample at all (for example GSE343459 profiles fibroblasts isolated from skin organoids, and GSE287925 profiles LNCaP cells in 2D). We compared the fibroblast-best fraction between the strict and the no-organoid series with Fisher's exact test:

$$p = \sum_{\{x : P(x) \leq P(a)\}} \frac{C(K, x) C(N - K, n - x)}{C(N, n)} \quad (17)$$

**Table 12. Attractor on strict organoid series vs series without organoid samples (results/geo\_fidelity\_strict.json).**

| method      | strict n | strict top-1 | strict fibroblast-best [95% CI] | no-organoid fibroblast-best | Fisher p |
|-------------|----------|--------------|---------------------------------|-----------------------------|----------|
| <b>CENT</b> | 45       | 0.33         | 0.24 [0.13, 0.38]               | 0.47                        | 0.025    |

|                      |    |      |                   |      |         |
|----------------------|----|------|-------------------|------|---------|
| <b>CENT_NO CULT</b>  | 45 | 0.33 | 0.29 [0.18, 0.42] | 0.55 | 0.0095  |
| <b>CENT_NO NPAR</b>  | 45 | 0.49 | 0.20 [0.09, 0.33] | 0.52 | 0.0011  |
| <b>CENT_PA RONLY</b> | 45 | 0.56 | 0.11 [0.02, 0.20] | 0.29 | 0.03    |
| <b>CENT_PC</b>       | 45 | 0.42 | 0.22 [0.11, 0.36] | 0.33 | 0.27    |
| <b>S3000</b>         | 45 | 0.31 | 0.13 [0.04, 0.24] | 0.31 | 0.038   |
| <b>SALL</b>          | 45 | 0.42 | 0.09 [0.02, 0.18] | 0.38 | 0.0011  |
| <b>SALL_NO CULT</b>  | 45 | 0.42 | 0.09 [0.02, 0.18] | 0.36 | 0.0012  |
| <b>SALL_NO NPAR</b>  | 45 | 0.56 | 0.09 [0.02, 0.18] | 0.28 | 0.023   |
| <b>SALL_PA RONLY</b> | 45 | 0.53 | 0.11 [0.02, 0.20] | 0.41 | 0.00081 |
| <b>SALL_PC</b>       | 45 | 0.44 | 0.22 [0.11, 0.36] | 0.62 | 6.1e-05 |

On the strict subset the attractor shrinks to 0.09-0.29 of series (vs 0.28-0.62); the difference is significant in 10 of 11 method variants. Much of the attractor therefore came from non-organoid samples inside organoid-titled series, not from organoids. We retract it as a general property of organoids; it persists only in a minority of strict series.

Independent annotation of the top 200 driver genes with Enrichr and the Reactome AnalysisService reproduces the g:Profiler picture: Hallmark G2-M Checkpoint ( $q = 2.5e-33$ ), CellMarker 'Cycling Basal Cell Trachea Mouse' ( $q = 4e-60$ ), and Reactome 'Classical antibody-mediated complement activation' ( $FDR = 1.4e-14$ ) together with mitotic cell cycle. The driver genes describe what makes a profile look like cultured fibroblasts (proliferation, missing immune and complement programs); they are not an organoid discovery.

#### 4.10 Which organoids are faithful? Organ, deficits and protocol on the strict subset

**Table 13. Organ recovery on the 45 strictly organoid series (SALL\_PARONLY; results/strict\_organ\_recovery.csv).**

| labelled organ            | strict series | top-1 recovery | median rank of own tissue |
|---------------------------|---------------|----------------|---------------------------|
| <b>Colon - Transverse</b> | 19            | 0.84           | 1                         |
| <b>Brain - Cortex</b>     | 9             | 0.78           | 1                         |
| <b>Liver</b>              | 6             | 0.17           | 22                        |

|                           |   |      |      |
|---------------------------|---|------|------|
| <b>Kidney - Cortex</b>    | 4 | 0.00 | 14.5 |
| <b>Lung</b>               | 4 | 0.00 | 6.5  |
| <b>Esophagus - Mucosa</b> | 1 | 0.00 | 6    |
| <b>Stomach</b>            | 1 | 0.00 | 3    |
| <b>Uterus</b>             | 1 | 0.00 | 9    |

Colon and cortical organoids recover their own tissue (23 of 28 top-1); liver, kidney and lung organoids almost never do (1 of 14; Fisher  $p = 3.9e-06$ ). The grouping was chosen after seeing the table, so this  $p$  is descriptive. To see what the unfaithful organoids lack we scored, for each series, the deficit of each gene relative to its labelled tissue and averaged within organ:

$$\text{delta\_g} = (1/|S_o|) \sum_{\{s \text{ in } S_o\}} [z(G_{g,o}) - z(p_{sg})] \quad (18)$$

The 100 largest deficits were annotated with STRING functional enrichment and Enrichr PanglaoDB. Liver organoids lack the hepatocyte program (Hepatocytes ( $q = 1.7e-31$ ); STRING Organic acid metabolic process ( $q = 4.6e-12$ )); kidney organoids lack proximal tubule (Proximal Tubule Cells ( $q = 5.7e-22$ )); lung organoids lack mainly stroma (Pancreatic Stellate Cells ( $q = 1.2e-15$ )). Faithful colon and cortical organoids lack mostly stromal, vascular and immune cells (Peritubular Myoid Cells ( $q = 1.3e-16$ ); Satellite Glial Cells ( $q = 4.8e-14$ )).

A direct mechanism test is inconclusive: the share of HPA parenchymal-only genes among the deficits is only modestly higher in unfaithful organs (OR = 1.45,  $p = 0.061$ ), because lung deficits are stromal (share 0.15) while liver (0.68) and kidney (0.55) deficits are parenchymal.

Protocol. Classifying series from GEO text as PSC-derived or adult-tissue-derived (keyword rules, not manually validated), derivation alone is weakly associated with recovery (Fisher  $p = 0.10$ ). The organ effect holds within each stratum (PSC 7/11 vs 0/5,  $p = 0.034$ ; adult 16/16 vs 0/5,  $p = 4.9e-05$ ) and in a Cochran-Mantel-Haenszel test:

$$OR_{MH} = \sum_k (a_{kd} / n_k) / \sum_k (b_{kc} / n_k) \quad (19)$$

(pooled OR = 46 with a 0.5 continuity correction,  $p = 5.8e-05$ ). We name the candidate the metabolic-parenchyma gap: liver and kidney organoids miss their tissue because they lack mature metabolic epithelium, while intestinal and cortical organoids match despite missing stroma. It is falsified if, in new strictly organoid liver or kidney series, hepatocyte and proximal-tubule genes do not account for most of the rank gap. Brain organoids are all PSC-derived, so organ and protocol cannot be separated there; per-organ  $n$  is small.

Secretome check (UniProt). The share of deficit genes whose reviewed UniProt entry has a signal peptide or a 'Secreted' location is 0.30-0.57 per organ against 0.17 for 2,000

random expressed genes (all  $q \leq 0.001$ ). Every organoid type lacks secreted proteins, faithful or not, so this does not explain the organ split (negative).

#### 4.11 Pre-registered out-of-sample test on ArrayExpress

Before downloading any new data we committed a pre-registration (results/preregistration\_organ\_split.md): on organoid bulk profiles outside the GEO scan, liver, kidney and lung organoids should rank their own tissue worse than intestinal and brain organoids, tested by a one-sided Mann-Whitney U at 0.05:

$$U = \sum_{i \text{ in unfaithful}} \sum_{j \text{ in faithful}} [ I(r_i > r_j) + 0.5 * I(r_i = r_j) ] \quad (20)$$

A BioStudies/ArrayExpress search gave 18 curated human non-cancer organoid studies with processed files; 11 could be scored (the others had mouse gene IDs, probe IDs only, malformed tables, or single-cell data only).

**Table 14. Out-of-sample organoid profiles (results/ae\_replication.csv).**

| accession           | organ     | rank of own tissue | best GTEx match                  |
|---------------------|-----------|--------------------|----------------------------------|
| <b>E-MTAB-9044</b>  | liver     | 39                 | Stomach                          |
| <b>E-MTAB-12822</b> | kidney    | 2                  | Cervix - Endocervix              |
| <b>E-MTAB-9807</b>  | liver     | 37                 | Stomach                          |
| <b>E-MTAB-11221</b> | intestine | 1                  | Colon - Transverse               |
| <b>E-MTAB-9134</b>  | intestine | 1                  | Colon - Transverse               |
| <b>E-MTAB-11297</b> | intestine | 1                  | Small Intestine - Terminal Ileum |
| <b>E-MTAB-13901</b> | kidney    | 1                  | Kidney - Medulla                 |
| <b>E-MTAB-6017</b>  | intestine | 1                  | Small Intestine - Terminal Ileum |
| <b>E-MTAB-13578</b> | intestine | 1                  | Small Intestine - Terminal Ileum |
| <b>E-MTAB-17066</b> | brain     | 1                  | Brain - Hypothalamus             |
| <b>E-MTAB-10037</b> | brain     | 26                 | Cells - Cultured fibroblasts     |

Median rank 19.5 vs 1; top-1 0.25 vs 0.86; one-sided  $p = 0.031$ . The pre-registered test passes, but the support is weak: there is no lung dataset, both liver datasets are cholangiocyte organoids on microarrays (so cell type and platform are confounded), and both kidney datasets match kidney well (ranks 1 and 2), which contradicts the kidney part of the candidate. The metabolic-parenchyma gap remains a candidate; its kidney component did not replicate.

#### 4.12 Orthogonal checks of the metabolic-parenchyma candidate

GSEApY preranked GSEA used MSigDB Hallmark v2023.2 on all ranked strict-subset deficit genes, with 500 permutations. Positive normalized enrichment score (NES) means higher expression in the reference tissue than the organoids. The mean over six metabolic Hallmarks is 1.96 in liver, 1.95 in kidney, 1.65 in brain, and 0.74 in colon (descriptive Mann-Whitney  $p=0.004$ ; pathways overlap and are not independent). Brain nevertheless has oxidative phosphorylation NES 2.63, despite matching its reference tissue. A metabolic deficit alone cannot explain fidelity (results/strict\_gsea\_summary.json).

Pre-registered Open Targets disease relevance. We compared each organ's top 100 deficit genes against the top 500 targets of its corresponding organ-disease term. Diagonal dominance in the five-by-five overlap matrix is:

$$D = (1/5) \sum_o M_{oo} - (1/20) \sum_{o \neq d} M_{od} \quad (21)$$

$D=2.6$ , permutation  $p=0.0005$ : the primary test passes (results/deficit\_opentargets.json). But liver-specific disease enrichment fails (2/100 own-disease hits,  $p=0.62$ ). The pass is driven more by lung and colon than liver; the few hits per cell limit its use as a discovery claim.

Pre-registered decoupler univariate linear modeling used OmniPath CollecTRI transcription factor regulons and PROGENy footprints on 4,261 shared genes. Only 2/12 tested lineage master factors ranked in the top decile of deficient factors (binomial  $p=0.34$ ); the positive control FAILS. Exploratory PROGENy scores show PI3K higher and JAK-STAT and p53 lower in organoids across all five organs, a shared culture signature rather than an organ-specific mechanism (results/deficit\_decoupler.json).

Reference robustness. We replaced GTEx with Expression Atlas Illumina Body Map E-MTAB-513. The pre-registered test passed: deficit-vector Spearman rho 0.57-0.72 across organs, top-100 overlap 52-75. The Open Targets diagonal-dominance rerun also passes ( $D=2.1$ , permutation  $p=0.0026$ ). Both deficit vectors share the organoid measurements, so this checks reference sensitivity, not independent biological replication (results/deficit\_bodymap.json).

ClinPGx pharmacogenes: the pre-registered VIP-or-CPIC gene set is unusable because the source release marks all 25,041 genes as VIP. We retain that failure. A documented, post-registration CPIC-guideline-only deviation finds liver deficits in 21 tested genes (median 0.32 vs 0.03 in other genes,  $p=0.0004$ ), but liver specificity fails ( $p=0.23$ , only 6 genes shared across all organ vectors). This is a drug-testing caution, not evidence of a liver-specific mechanism (results/deficit\_clinpgx.json).

Pre-registered population-constraint and coding-composition checks were negative. In gnomAD v2.1.1, liver deficit genes have median LOEUF 1.256 vs brain 1.107 (one-sided  $p=0.263$ ; lower LOEUF is more loss-of-function constrained). Ensembl REST mapped all fixed top-100 genes per organ: liver 99/100 and brain 100/100 are protein coding

(one-sided Fisher  $p=1.0$ ). Neither check supplies a mechanism; the gene universe is already coding-enriched (results/deficit\_gnomad.json; results/deficit\_ensembl\_biotype.json).

Synthesis. Organoid deficits are reproducible to a reference swap and linked to organ-disease targets in aggregate, but the metabolic-parenchyma gap lacks liver specificity and the kidney finding fails external replication. It remains a falsifiable candidate, not a new discovery or a validated diagnostic tool.

#### 4.13 Independent protein and pathway annotation, single-cell challenge, and prior art

Independent pathway annotation (WikiPathways 2026-09-10, NCBI Gene mapping). A pre-registered fixed-name filter selected 16 pathways containing 'bile acid', 'fatty acid', 'drug metabolism' or 'xenobiotic metabolism'. Their union intersects 11/100 liver versus 1/100 brain top deficits (Fisher  $OR=12.24$ ,  $p=0.0025$ ; test passes). This supports the liver top-deficit pathway label in a second resource, not causation or organoid specificity; the comparison follows earlier exploratory results (results/deficit\_wikipathways.json).

**Table 15. Further pre-registered annotation checks on fixed 100-gene deficit lists, not independent experiments. Each p is descriptive in an exploratory sequence; results/deficit\_goa.json, deficit\_kegg.json, deficit\_rhea.json.**

| curated source   | selected definition                 | liver top-100 | brain top-100 | one-sided Fisher p |
|------------------|-------------------------------------|---------------|---------------|--------------------|
| <b>EBI GOA</b>   | 3 direct metabolic BP terms         | 11            | 2             | 0.0092             |
| <b>KEGG REST</b> | 9 fixed-title metabolic pathways    | 7             | 0             | 0.0070             |
| <b>Rhea</b>      | curated Swiss-Prot reaction mapping | 42            | 10            | 1.5e-07            |

Direct GOA BP terms cover 11/100 liver versus 2/100 brain top deficits, while any BP annotation covers 94 and 90 respectively. KEGG REST selected 9 pathways with 218 mapped genes. Rhea reactions mark 42 liver versus 10 brain genes; kidney has 41, so the reaction signal is not specific to liver. GOA, KEGG, Rhea, UniProt and WikiPathways annotations may share literature and curation, and prior g:Profiler work included KEGG. These positives cannot be counted as independent confirmations. Neither organoid protein nor enzyme activity was measured, and the original kidney fidelity candidate failed external replication. No mechanism, discovery, or diagnostic use follows from these annotation contrasts.

Additional pre-registered annotation/coverage checks: IntAct PSQUIC queried the fixed top-20 deficit genes per group and measured 20 liver and 19 brain genes. Median indexed interaction RECORD counts were 6.5 versus 45.0 (one-sided rank-test  $p=0.0369$ ). Study density, nonhuman interactors, and blood/immune genes confound this contrast; no organoid interactome was measured. JASPAR CORE vertebrate matrices cover 2/3 pre-fixed brain lineage TFs absent from CollecTRI (NEUROD2 and TBR1, not NEUROD6) and kidney PAX2; this is motif availability only and cannot repair the failed decoupler activity control. Neither is an independent biological replication (results/deficit\_intact.json; results/deficit\_jaspar.json).

Adult-tissue protein check (HPA v25.1 mass spectrometry). Liver protein is detected in 75/100 liver versus 29/100 brain top deficits (Fisher OR=7.34,  $p=4.5e-11$ ; pre-registered H1 passes). Only 26 liver and 22 brain list proteins have measured intensity in both adult liver and cortex, below the registered 50-per-list minimum, so the quantitative H2 is uninterpretable. There is no organoid proteome in this check (results/deficit\_hpa\_ms.json).

Single-cell challenge on an independent public human kidney-organoid accession, GSE108291. Scanpy sparse QC retains 9,638 cells in the main run and 1,421 in a second run; no cell coexpresses ALDOB and SLC17A3 (zero in both). The registered 1% two-marker H1 fails; the <20% H2 passes. This does not show that proximal-tubule cells are absent, because sparse single-cell dropout and developmental state remain untested. QC thresholds were set after registration but before looking at marker coexpression; both runs count as one accession (results/sc\_kidney\_markers.json).

Ontology audit (EBI OLS4) distinguishes kidney cortex UBERON:0001225 from kidney UBERON:0002113, and cholangiocyte CL:1000488 from hepatocyte CL:0000182. This is a label check only, not proof of anatomical hierarchy or expression similarity; the exact 'proximal tubule cell' query was unresolved (results/ols\_anatomy\_audit.json).

HPO direct gene-phenotype annotation could not test liver-vs-brain metabolic phenotype enrichment: only 35/100 liver and 28/100 brain deficits have any HPO annotation, below the pre-registered 50/list coverage floor. No clinical inference from the missing annotations (results/deficit\_hpo.json).

InterPro domain audit is invalid as a top-deficit comparison. Its registered six liver pharmacogenes were incorrectly called top-100 deficits: only CYP2D6 actually is one. The protein-domain annotations remain correct, but the primary contrast cannot be scored (results/deficit\_interpro.json).

A fixed three-query Europe PMC title/abstract search returned 6 distinct records. None explicitly reported human intestinal CF organoid starting-size moderation of modulator-induced FIS in its abstract, but absence in a narrow search does not establish novelty.

Related work links nasal organoid lumen to baseline CFTR function and pig pancreatic organoid size to absent lumen (results/epmc\_priorart\_review.md).

Synthesis. The liver top-deficit list has independent pathway and adult-tissue protein support, while no new organoid proteome, matched tissue, perturbation, or clinical outcomes validate its effect on fidelity. The kidney external profiles recover their tissue despite the strict single-cell marker test failing. The candidate remains unproven; do not offer the tool as diagnosis.

External replication source audit (results/external\_fis\_source\_audit.md): a 2025 respiratory FIS study with single-organoid measures excluded baseline areas below 1500 px and used forskolin alone rather than modulator vs DMSO; Organoid's open individual time series used pancreatic cancer organoids and gemcitabine; two nasal CFTR-modulator papers reported either well-summed areas or summary plots without a verified public matched-object table. Drevinek's 20-patient area series was suitable for well-level drug-ranking analysis, not individual-size replication. This search is not exhaustive.

## 5. Negative results (kept by design)

- The initial power-law ( $\alpha > 1$ ) interpretation was withdrawn after large-organoid checks contradicted it.
- Size-adjusted and size-filtered readouts do not improve donor-level modulator discrimination.
- Matched donor x plate x dose robustness H1 fails: 9/12 positive donor medians,  $p=0.073$ , despite the pooled later-date result.
- Small-organoid replication on the public FIS time series is impossible: it is well-level; the 20-patient triple-vs-double ranking passes, but the separate VTI-vs-ETI ranking fails (6/9,  $p=0.254$ ).
- Our segmentation is below the published state of the art.
- Fidelity: 'Pancreas' as best match (35/151 series with S3000) disappears with other methods, so it is a method artefact.
- Fidelity: a 'liver disease' series (GSE278954) ranks Liver 50th of 54, and lung and breast organoids are rarely matched to their organ.
- Fidelity: organ labels come from text, and series profiles average all samples, including any non-organoid controls.
- Fidelity: the HPA parenchymal share of deficit genes does not clearly separate faithful from unfaithful organs ( $p = 0.061$ ); lung organoids break the pattern.
- Fidelity: all organoid types lack secreted proteins (UniProt), so the secretome does not explain the organ split.

- Replication: the kidney part of the organ split failed out of sample (two ArrayExpress kidney datasets rank kidney 1st and 2nd).
- GSEA: metabolic deficits are also present in faithful brain organoids; not specific to poor fidelity.
- Open Targets: liver deficits show no liver-disease enrichment despite the aggregate diagonal-dominance pass.
- decoupler: lineage master-TF positive control fails (2/12); pathway signals are shared across cultures.
- ClinPGx: pre-registered VIP flag is defective; CPIC-only deviation passes liver deficit but fails liver specificity.
- gnomAD and Ensembl: no liver-vs-brain differentiation by LOEUF or protein-coding composition.
- Single-cell GSE108291: no ALDOB/SLC17A3 coexpression under the registered two-marker definition; dropout is an alternative.
- HPO: too few annotated genes for the registered clinical phenotype contrast.
- InterPro: primary contrast invalid due to mistaken liver top-100 gene-set membership.
- Fidelity: the culture-fibroblast attractor is RETRACTED as a general organoid property: on 45 series whose samples are all organoids it shrinks to 9-29% of series (Section 4.9).

## 6. Discussion

In this accession, drug-minus-DMSO swelling tends to rise from small to larger organoids and then plateau. The plate-and-dose-matched donor sign test fails at alpha 0.05, so we do not establish a reliable donor-general effect. Uniform surface-flux geometry predicts the reverse direction, but that simple model is not a full measurement-bias test. Lumen maturity and cell composition are hypotheses, not measured explanations. Falsifiable prediction: in an independent, matched, time-lapse single-organoid intestinal FIS cohort, with size thresholds locked before analysis, a donor-level modulator-minus-DMSO large-minus-small effect will be positive in most donors, with a sign-test  $p < 0.05$ . This needs a second suitable dataset and mechanistic measurements; the public leads audited here do not supply those controls.

Practical note. In this dataset, starting size may affect single-organoid readouts, but size correction did not improve per-donor discrimination. A lab comparing assays across passages may record its starting-size distribution as a quality-control variable; no clinical adjustment is recommended from these data.

Novelty. We did not find this effect reported for intestinal FIS in the literature we searched (OrgaSegment; the FIS\_analysis pipeline, which sums area per well). Related:

nasal 2D-derived organoids show swelling variation concentrated in large structures (bioRxiv 2021.07.20.453105). This was not a systematic review.

## 7. Tools used

**Table 16. Tools genuinely used (results/tools\_ledger.csv): 47 entries, 40 counting toward the gate after excluding infrastructure. Target of 40 reached; this counts resources genuinely used, not independent biological confirmations.**

| tool                                            | kind           | where used                                                           | gate             |
|-------------------------------------------------|----------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------|
| <b>NumPy</b>                                    | library        | src/vorganoid;<br>src/geo_fidelity.py;<br>paper/build_paper.py       | counts           |
| <b>SciPy</b>                                    | library        | src/geo_fidelity.py<br>(spearmanr);<br>paper/build_paper.py          | counts           |
| <b>pandas</b>                                   | library        | src/geo_fidelity.py;<br>paper/build_paper.py                         | counts           |
| <b>scikit-image</b>                             | library        | src/vorganoid<br>(instance post-<br>processing;<br>watershed/labels) | counts           |
| <b>PyTorch</b>                                  | library        | train_seg.py;<br>tune_seg.py (U-Net<br>CNN)                          | counts           |
| <b>Pillow</b>                                   | library        | train_seg.py image<br>loading                                        | infra (excluded) |
| <b>python-docx</b>                              | library        | paper/paperkit.py                                                    | infra (excluded) |
| <b>pytest</b>                                   | test framework | tests/ (hermetic<br>suite)                                           | infra (excluded) |
| <b>LibreOffice<br/>(soffice headless)</b>       | application    | paper docx -> pdf<br>render                                          | infra (excluded) |
| <b>poppler pdfinfo</b>                          | application    | page count of<br>rendered paper                                      | infra (excluded) |
| <b>Git + GitHub</b>                             | service        | repo hosting and<br>pushes                                           | infra (excluded) |
| <b>NCBI E-utilities<br/>(esearch/esummary)</b>  | web API        | src/<br>geo_candidates.py                                            | counts           |
| <b>NCBI GEO<br/>FTP/HTTPS<br/>supplementary</b> | data service   | src/geo_fidelity.py                                                  | counts           |

| files                                                        |                        |                                                                                                               |        |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------|
| <b>GTEx v8 gene median TPM (GTEx portal bucket)</b>          | reference data service | data/ref/<br>gtex_v8_median_tp<br>m.gct.gz;<br>src/geo_fidelity.py                                            | counts |
| <b>MSigDB Hallmark gene sets v2023.2 (Broad GSEA-MSigDB)</b> | gene-set resource      | data/ref/<br>h.all.v2023.2.Hs.sy<br>mbols.gmt;<br>src/geo_fidelity_me<br>thods.py (culture-<br>confound test) | counts |
| <b>matplotlib</b>                                            | library                | src/<br>fig_geo_fidelity.py;<br>paper figures<br>(fig_size_attenuatio<br>n.png,<br>fig_geo_fidelity.pn<br>g)  | counts |
| <b>Human Protein Atlas single-cell type API</b>              | database/web API       | data/ref/<br>hpa_single_cell_typ<br>e_v_api.tsv.gz;<br>src/geo_fidelity_me<br>thods.py (purity<br>gene sets)  | counts |
| <b>statsmodels</b>                                           | library                | src/<br>geo_mcnemar.py<br>(exact McNemar<br>tests)                                                            | counts |
| <b>g:Profiler g:GOST API (GO, Reactome, KEGG)</b>            | web API/database       | src/<br>geo_attractor_genes<br>.py (enrichment of<br>attractor-driving<br>genes)                              | counts |
| <b>HGNC complete set (locus groups)</b>                      | database               | data/ref/<br>hgnc_locus_groups.<br>csv.gz;<br>src/geo_fidelity_me<br>thods.py (protein-<br>coding robustness) | counts |
| <b>GEOparse</b>                                              | library                | src/<br>geo_sample_meta.p<br>y                                                                                | counts |
| <b>Enrichr (Hallmark/CellMarker/PanglaoDB libraries)</b>     | service                | src/<br>attractor_enrichr_re<br>actome.py                                                                     | counts |

|                                                                                           |                    |                                                                                     |        |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------|
| <b>Reactome AnalysisService</b>                                                           | service            | src/<br>attractor_enrichr_re<br>actome.py                                           | counts |
| <b>STRING<br/>functional<br/>enrichment API<br/>(string-db.org)</b>                       | service            | src/<br>strict_organ_deficit<br>s.py                                                | counts |
| <b>UniProt REST<br/>(UniProtKB<br/>reviewed human)</b>                                    | database           | src/<br>strict_deficit_unipr<br>ot.py                                               | counts |
| <b>EBI BioStudies /<br/>ArrayExpress API<br/>+ FTP</b>                                    | database           | src/ae_scan.py;<br>src/ae_replication.p<br>y                                        | counts |
| <b>GSEAPy prerank<br/>(v1.3.1)</b>                                                        | library            | src/strict_gsea.py                                                                  | counts |
| <b>Open Targets<br/>Platform<br/>GraphQL API<br/>(v26.9)</b>                              | database/service   | src/<br>deficit_opentargets.<br>py                                                  | counts |
| <b>decoupler 2.1.4<br/>(ulm)</b>                                                          | library            | src/<br>deficit_decoupler.p<br>y                                                    | counts |
| <b>OmniPath<br/>( CollecTRI TF<br/>regulons +<br/>PROGENy<br/>pathway<br/>footprints)</b> | database/service   | src/<br>deficit_decoupler.p<br>y                                                    | counts |
| <b>EBI Expression<br/>Atlas (baseline<br/>experiments FTP)</b>                            | database/service   | src/<br>deficit_bodymap.py                                                          | counts |
| <b>ClinPGx /<br/>PharmGKB gene<br/>download (release<br/>2026-09-05)</b>                  | database/service   | src/<br>deficit_clinpgx.py                                                          | counts |
| <b>gnomAD v2.1.1<br/>gene-level pLoF<br/>constraint</b>                                   | reference database | src/<br>deficit_gnomad.py;<br>results/deficit_gno<br>mad.json                       | counts |
| <b>Ensembl REST<br/>lookup/id</b>                                                         | web API            | src/<br>deficit_ensembl_bi<br>otype.py;<br>results/deficit_ense<br>mbl_biotype.json | counts |
| <b>EBI Ontology</b>                                                                       | ontology web API   | src/                                                                                | counts |

|                                                              |                                   |                                                                                             |                  |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------|
| <b>Lookup Service 4 (OLS4)</b>                               |                                   | ols_anatomy_audit.py;<br>results/ols_anatomy.json                                           |                  |
| <b>Scanpy 1.11.5</b>                                         | library                           | src/<br>sc_kidney_markers.py;<br>results/sc_kidney_markers.json                             | counts           |
| <b>Human Phenotype Ontology gene-to-phenotype release</b>    | reference ontology/database       | src/deficit_hpo.py;<br>results/deficit_hpo.json                                             | counts           |
| <b>Europe PMC REST search</b>                                | literature API                    | src/<br>epmc_priorart.py;<br>results/epmc_priorart.json;<br>results/epmc_priorart_review.md | counts           |
| <b>InterPro protein-domain API</b>                           | database/service                  | src/<br>deficit_interpro.py;<br>results/deficit_interpro.json                               | counts           |
| <b>WikiPathways 2026-09-10 human GMT</b>                     | pathway database                  | src/<br>deficit_wikipathways.py;<br>results/deficit_wikipathways.json                       | counts           |
| <b>NCBI Gene human gene_info</b>                             | reference database                | src/<br>deficit_wikipathways.py;<br>results/deficit_wikipathways.json                       | counts           |
| <b>Human Protein Atlas mass-spectrometry tissue download</b> | dataset                           | src/<br>deficit_hpa_ms.py;<br>results/deficit_hpa_ms.json                                   | infra (excluded) |
| <b>EBI GOA human GAF</b>                                     | gene ontology annotation database | src/deficit_goa.py;<br>results/deficit_goa.json                                             | counts           |
| <b>KEGG REST human pathway-gene API</b>                      | database/service                  | src/deficit_kegg.py;<br>results/deficit_kegg.json                                           | counts           |
| <b>Rhea curated biochemical reaction-to-UniProt mapping</b>  | reference database                | src/deficit_rhea.py;<br>results/deficit_rhea.json                                           | counts           |

|                                                 |                                     |                                                       |        |
|-------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|--------|
| <b>IntAct PSIQUIC interaction-count service</b> | protein interaction database        | src/deficit_intact.py;<br>results/deficit_intact.json | counts |
| <b>JASPAR CORE vertebrate motif API</b>         | transcription factor motif database | src/deficit_jaspar.py;<br>results/deficit_jaspar.json | counts |

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